The public anger and anguish caused by the devastation of the Covid second wave had put the Modi government on the defensive. The opposition parties also did their damnedest to corner the government on its handling of the pandemic, yet more than half the respondents (53 per cent) believe opposition parties criticised the government for the heck of it; only 32 per cent said the opposition held the government to account in a constructive manner.

The apparent lack of faith in the Opposition seems to bear a direct relationship to the performance of the Congress. Two lacklustre performances in back-to-back Lok Sabha elections (2014 and 2019) and the unending uncertainty over the top leadership have badly dented public perception of the only truly national Opposition party. The public feud among leaders in the handful of states it rules has not helped matters either. Consequently, as seen in successive MOTN polls, popular support for the party has declined—with only 33 per cent rating its performance as 'good' in this edition, down from 41 per cent in January 2021.

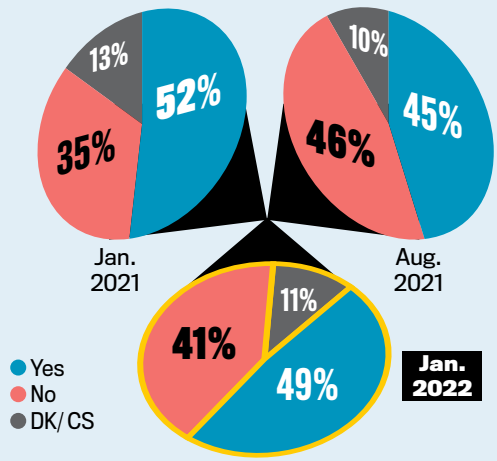
58.3% RESPONDENTS FROM THE WEST THINK THE **CONGRESS WOULD BE BETTER OFF WITHOUT THE GANDHIS**

Despite unrelenting criticism from the BJP and even other opposition parties, Rahul Gandhi remains the best bet for the party to chart a revival—nearly 18 per cent respondents backed him as the best suited leader to revive the Congress, down from 24 per cent in January 2020 but up from 15 per cent a year ago. However, a growing number (49 per cent in this edition from 45 per cent six months ago) think the Congress will be better off without the Gandhis.

Congress president Sonia Gandhi and AICC general secretary in-charge of Uttar Pradesh Priyanka Gandhi have seen a dip in popular support. In fact, Priyanka, who is trying to engineer the party's revival in UP and spearheading its campaign in the state for the forthcoming assembly election, has slipped to #4 in the list of leaders best suited to revive the party.

In contrast, 30 per cent respondents back 89-year-old Manmohan Singh to head the Congress (up from 27 per cent a year ago). The next most popular (12 per cent) non-Gandhi is 44-year-old Sachin Pilot, former

Q. DO YOU THINK THE CONGRESS WILL BE BETTER OFF WITHOUT THE GANDHI FAMILY?



Q. HOW DO YOU PERCEIVE THE ROLE OF THE OPPOSITION PARTIES DURING THE PANDEMIC?

	Jan. 2022	Aug. 2021	Jan. 2021	Aug. 2020
They criticised the government for the sake of criticism	53%	51%	49%	53%
They held the govt accountable with constructive criticism	32%	37%	38%	33%
DK/ CS	15%	12%	13%	14%

Q. WHO AMONG THE NON-GANDHI LEADERS IS BEST SUITED TO LEAD THE CONGRESS?

	Jan. 2022	Aug. 2021	Jan. 2021
MANMOHAN SINGH	30%	28%	27%
SACHIN PILOT	12%	17%	17%
P. CHIDAMBARAM	5%	7%	8%
ASHOK GEHLOT	4%	6%	6%
KAMAL NATH	4%	9%	8%
GHULAM NABI AZAD	4%	5%	4%

Rest: Others